

the district. "Mandya is like India, it has all the variety and it is a challenge for all officers. If you serve here, learn the rudiments, you can serve anywhere in the country," he says.

Election tehsildar, 24-year-old R. Meghana is an arts graduate and is the youngest of the group, but it is thanks to her that recent elections to local bodies in the taluks were incident-free. She worked with the district police and administrative machinery to ensure a free and fair poll. Mandya is also the first district in the state to be ready with a fresh electoral roll for the upcoming elections. The officers weeded out more than a lakh ineligible voters—read dead—while preparing the list. For the corrupt politician, this is usually a goldmine to be struck. But the women officers ensured a door-to-door check was carried out to stamp out the wrongs in the system. "We hope we can make a small difference," says Meghana.

A postgraduate in Kannada language, 34-year-old Dhanalakshmi is the tehsildar of Malavalli taluk and has been responsible for ending kerosene adulteration in her taluk.

Another officer, assistant director of food and civil supplies in Mandya district Kumuda Girish, 29, cracked down on more than 20,000 bogus BPL (below poverty line) ration cards holders, much to the consternation of local politicians, but she refused to budge from her position.

In October 2007, R. Kavitha Rani, 30, tehsildar of Srirangapatna and her boss B.R. Poornima, 34, assistant commissioner of Pandavapura subdivision, achieved in less than a week what their predecessors could not in four previous decades—clearing the encroachments around the Lord Ranganathaswamy Temple at Sriran-

gapatna. They also recovered the two-and-half acre former Garrison Hospital property near the Fort Wall and handed it over to the Archaeological Department. The Garrison Hospital walls are in ruins but the land, abutting the Cauvery river, could have been any resort owner's pride. The day the raids took place, both Rani and Poornima had switched off their mobile phones. Some of their underlings had managed to leak information to encroachers and the offenders were at the site as early as 5:30 in the morning bargaining for time to move out—a

amassed in four months. One temple in Melkote alone has accumulated about Rs 3 lakh. The officers have ensured for the first time that the opening of the hundi and counting of money is video-graphed with tapes sent to them later.

Former high court advocate and documentary filmmaker R. Suma, 33, now tehsildar of Krishnarajapet taluk, 70 km from Mandya town, was responsible for bringing to an end illegal sand quarrying on the Hemavathi riverbank. A music buff, Suma is single but says she has always wanted to be in public service. "I don't

DYNAMIC DUO: Poornima (left) and Kavitha Rani at a recovered property



ploy to actually obtain court stay. Prasad was later inundated with phone calls but he handled them with care, according to Rani and Poornima. The absence of a politically-elected government has helped as there is little interference from higher-ups.

The duo, Poornima and Rani, have also brought in transparency in the counting of temple collections. Collections in the hundis of several temples, including the famous Nimishamba temple at Srirangapatna, have gone up with a total Rs 15 lakh

mind the long hours of work, travelling from one village to the other." Former geography lecturer, V.R. Shylaja, 29, is tehsildar of Pandavapura taluk. She was earlier stationed at Magadi, Bangalore, but was sent away because of a tussle with a local politician. "Coming here has been such a blessing," she says, "to see so many women officers and share notes."

As Krishna Gowda, a farmer puts it, "The female officers are more sensitive. They listen to us and we believe they will do their jobs and meet our needs." The nine-woman squad meets at Prasad's bungalow at least once a fortnight when he calls them for a review, otherwise they don't get to spend much time together. But when they do, they easily stand out. ■



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N. MANJUNATHA PRASAD, DISTRICT COLLECTOR, MANDYA